



| CORPORATE **BISLERI** |

THIRSTING FOR ANCE

BY KRISHNA GOPALAN

ILLUSTRATIONS BY NILANJAN DAS

THERE IS A MOMENT from her teens that is etched in Jayanti Chauhan's memory. Accompanying her father, Ramesh Chauhan, often called the cola king, to the Evian mineral water bottling plant in France she was stunned by the sophistication. There were just three people on the shop floor at Évian-les-Bains (to the locals, it is just Évian) and it sparked a desire to have a plant like that.

"It was quite a revelation to see an automated pallet system. It must be even more sophisticated now," she says, still awestruck two decades later. Walking us through her own plant in Mumbai's suburb of Andheri, Chauhan, now Bisleri International's Vice Chairperson, grins when she points to just a handful of folks

on the factory floor. "We have also changed a lot. There are more machines now."

Chauhan grew up to the sound of Thums Up bottles on the assembly line when she visited the factory her family owned. In 1993, her father took the decision to sell the soft drinks business—it also had Gold Spot, Limca, Maa-za and Citra—to Coca-Cola for a reported \$60 million. It was a defining moment in the industry at that time and over the next five years Chauhan senior shifted focus to Bisleri.

Though it was acquired in 1969 from Italian owners, it wasn't until the turn of the century that the Bisleri brand came into its own (see graphic *A Brief History*). Today, it is a ₹1,645-crore company and the undisputed